

vomiting. He noted that “it comforts and strengthens the head, stomach, reins [ureters] and womb, expels wind and breaks the stone.” Carolus Linnaeus, the 18th-century Swedish naturalist, used the plant to treat headaches and hangovers.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Like its close relative thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143), wild thyme is antiseptic and antifungal. It may be taken as an infusion or syrup to treat flu and colds, sore throats, coughs, whooping cough, chest infections, and bronchitis. Wild thyme has anticongestion properties and helps clear a stuffy nose, sinusitis, ear congestion, and related complaints. It has been used to expel threadworms and roundworms in children, and is used to settle gas and colic. Wild thyme’s antispasmodic action makes it useful in relieving period pain. Externally, it may be applied as a poultice to treat mastitis (inflammation of the breast), and an infusion may be used as a wash to help heal wounds and ulcers. Wild thyme is also used in herbal baths and pillows.

Related Species See thyme (*T. vulgaris*, p. 143).

Caution For worms in children, use only under professional supervision.

Tilia spp. (Tiliaceae)

Linden, Lime

Description Deciduous trees growing to a height of 100 ft (30 m), with smooth gray bark, heart-shaped leaves, and clusters of pale yellow flowers with winglike bracts.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, linden is found in the wild, but is also much planted in gardens and along roads. The flowers are collected in summer.

Parts Used Flowers and bracts.

Constituents Linden contains flavonoids (especially quercetin and kaempferol), caffeic and other acids, mucilage (about 3%), tannins, volatile oil (0.02%–0.1%), and traces of benzodiazepine-like compounds. The flavonoids improve circulation.

History & Folklore Greek myth recounts how Philyra, a nymph, was raped by the god Cronus in the guise of a horse, and eventually gave birth to the famed centaur, Chiron. Philyra was so devastated that she

begged the gods not to leave her amongst mortals. The gods granted her wish by transforming her into a linden tree.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Linden is an antispasmodic, sweat-inducing, and sedative remedy. It relieves tension and sinus headaches, helping to calm the mind and allow easy sleep. Linden is an excellent remedy for stress and panic, and is used specifically to treat nervous palpitations. The flowers bring relief to colds and flu by reducing nasal congestion and soothing fever. Linden flowers are commonly taken to lower high blood pressure, particularly when there are emotional factors involved. The flowers are used over the long term to treat high systolic blood pressure associated with arteriosclerosis. Because of their emollient quality, linden flowers are used in France to make a lotion for itchy skin.

Trifolium pratense (Fabaceae)

Red Clover

Description Perennial herb growing to 16 in (40 cm). Has a hairy upright stem, leaves with 3 (or, rarely, 4) oval leaflets with a white crescent marking, and pink to purple egg-shaped flowerheads.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and Asia, and naturalized in North America and Australia, red clover is widely cultivated for hay and as a nitrogen-fixing crop. The flowerheads are collected when newly opened in summer.

Parts Used Flowerheads.

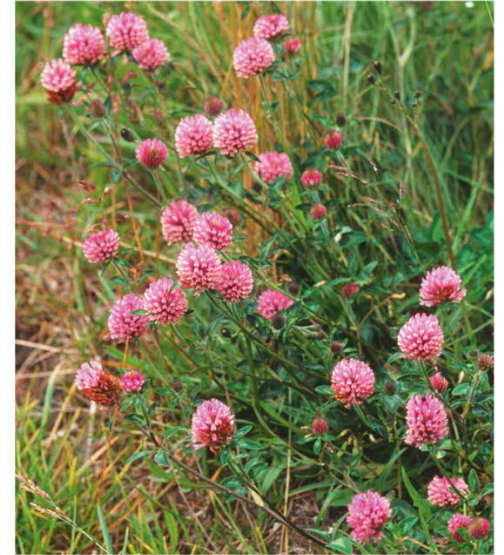
Constituents Red clover contains volatile oil, including benzyl alcohol and methyl salicylate, isoflavones, coumarins, and cyanogenic glycosides. The isoflavones occur at relatively high levels and are phytoestrogenic. The isolated isoflavones are marketed as a treatment for menopausal problems.

History & Folklore This herb has traditionally been used to treat breast cancer. A concentrated decoction was applied to the site of the tumor in order to encourage it to grow outward and clear the body.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Red clover is used to treat skin conditions, normally in combination with other purifying herbs such as burdock (*Arctium lappa*, p. 65) and yellow dock (*Rumex crispus*, p. 264). It is also expectorant and may be used for spasmodic coughs. Red clover’s significant phytoestrogenic activity has led to increasing use of the herb to relieve menopausal symptoms. In most cases it will be preferable to use extracts of red clover flowers rather than the isoflavones on their own.

Research The isoflavones have an established phytoestrogenic activity. Red clover isoflavones have been shown to have not only therapeutic use during menopause, helping to reduce the impact of

falling estrogen levels, but also to exert a protective effect on the heart and circulation in menopausal women with low estrogen levels. Early-stage research points to the isoflavones countering bone loss, making them potentially of use in osteoporosis. Due to the isoflavones’ ability to “compete” with the body’s own estrogen, it is now thought that red clover may be helpful in both preventing and treating breast cancer.



Red clover is a common roadside plant, but it is also cultivated as a fodder crop.

Trigonella foenum-graecum (Fabaceae)

Fenugreek

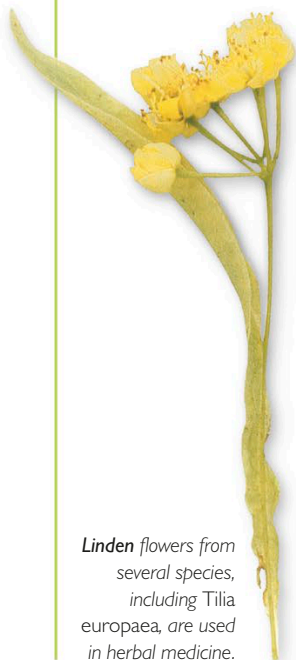
Description Strongly aromatic annual growing to about 32 in (80 cm). Has trifoliate leaves, yellowish-white pealike flowers, and sickle-shaped pods.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to North Africa and countries bordering the eastern Mediterranean, fenugreek grows in open areas and is widely cultivated, notably in India. The seeds are collected during the autumn months.

Parts Used Seeds.

Constituents Fenugreek contains a volatile oil, alkaloids (including trigonelline), saponins (based on diosgenin), flavonoids, mucilage (about 27%), protein (about 25%), fixed oil (approximately 8%), vitamins A, B₁ and C, and minerals.

History & Folklore The Egyptian Ebers papyrus, which dates from c. 1500 BCE, records a prescription for burns that includes fenugreek. The seeds were also used in ancient Egypt to induce childbirth. In the 5th century BCE the Greek physician Hippocrates considered fenugreek to be a valuable soothing herb. Dioscorides, writing in the 1st century CE, recommended fenugreek as a



Linden flowers from several species, including *Tilia europaea*, are used in herbal medicine.